Quebec premier boycotts Mark Carney's EU summit

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By Jacob Parry · Oct 29, 2026, 10:59 AM · View in your browser

Quebec's separatist premier says that he will boycott the EU-Canada summit that opens in Montreal on Thursday, warning European leaders that deals struck there without his government's consent may not be applied in the country's second-biggest province.

Paul St-Pierre Plamondon confirmed his absence late Wednesday in an open letter to the European delegation, which he posted on X . His announcement followed two days of public sparring with Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney over Ottawa's refusal to let him address the summit.

"This dynamic creates uncertainty as to the application of the agreements you could negotiate during the summit," he wrote in French.

In the letter, St-Pierre Plamondon says Ottawa has "decided to sideline Quebec" from the talks. He says this leaves his government with "neither a chair at the negotiating table nor the opportunity to speak," even though the summit is on Quebec soil.

Under Canada's federal system, he argued, the provinces implement international agreements that fall within their powers. Without Quebec's consent, a deal that runs against its interests "will simply not be implemented," he wrote. He also accused Ottawa of withholding "critical information" on the negotiations.

He offered to meet European leaders "in the near future, in a more opportune context." He will send Quebec's chief diplomat, Pascal Paradis, to the summit in his place.

Carney said Wednesday his office had offered the premier the honor of welcoming the Commission president to Montreal, and a seat at the head table. "I hope he will reconsider," he said. On Tuesday, the prime minister had accused St-Pierre Plamondon of choosing to "leave an empty chair again."

The row has soured the upbeat mood around the summit, which Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Council President António Costa have billed as a milestone. Leaders will launch an "Alliance for the Future ," a framework for shared prosperity and economic security.

St-Pierre Plamondon's letter says many of its topics fall under Quebec's responsibility, including health, education and natural resources.

The premier has also pursued his own contacts with European leaders.

He spoke by phone with French President Emmanuel Macron on Monday, and said the two had agreed on a possible meeting in France in the coming weeks.

At working level, ties have held so far, and officials describe the relationship as constructive.

Hélène Drainville, Quebec's delegate general in Brussels, told POLITICO last week that Quebec was in talks with the European Investment Bank and the Commission, and that "all the signals are green."

Carney, Costa and von der Leyen are due to hold a joint press conference on Friday.

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